Characteristics and Criteria of Profession in Nursing

Understanding Professional Development in Healthcare

Introduction to Professional Characteristics

Nursing has evolved from an occupation to an emerging profession, characterized by specific attributes that define professional practice.

Key Points:

- Historical evolution of nursing
- Current status as an emerging profession
- Importance of understanding professional characteristics

General Characteristics of a Profession

1. Authority to control its own work
2. Exclusive body of specialized knowledge
3. Extensive period of formal training
4. Specialized competence
5. Control over work performance
6. Service to society
7. Self-regulation
8. Credentialing system
9. Legal reinforcement
10. Ethical practice
11. Collegial subculture

Wickenden's Six Characteristics

1. **Specialized Service**
    - Based on advanced knowledge and skill
    - Primarily intellectual rather than physical
    - Problem-solving oriented
2. **Confidential Relationship**
    - Between practitioner and client
    - Professional trust and privacy
3. **Public Obligation**
    - Responsibility due to specialized knowledge
    - Commitment to public welfare

Wickenden's Characteristics (Continued)

4. **Common Heritage**
    - Shared knowledge and skills
    - Collective contribution to profession
5. **Public Interest Service**
    - Focus on general public benefit
    - Limited fees rather than direct profit
6. **Ethical Code**
    - Distinctive professional ethics
    - Guidelines for relationships with:
        - Clients

Categories of Professional Characteristics

1. Intellectual Category

- Body of Knowledge
  - Experience-based expertise
  - Research-based theoretical foundation
  - Continuous evolution of practice

Intellectual Category (Continued)

Specialized Education

- Multiple Educational Pathways:
    - Diploma
    - Associate degree
    - Baccalaureate degree
    - Master's degree
    - Doctoral degree

Critical and Creative Thinking

- Nursing Process Components:
    i. Information collection

Personal Category

Autonomy in Practice

- Independent decision-making
- Risk-taking ability
- Professional responsibility
- Self-determination
- Self-regulation

Key aspects:

- Accountability for actions
- Collaboration with healthcare team
- Patient-centered decision making

Interpersonal Category

Therapeutic Relationship

- Cooperative functioning
- Team collaboration
- Patient engagement

Professional Communication

- Multi-disciplinary approach
- Goal formulation
- Care planning
- Service delivery

Flexner's Criteria for a Profession

1. Intellectual work with high individual responsibility
2. Science-based knowledge
3. Practical and theoretical applications
4. Specialized professional education
5. Strong internal organization
6. Altruistic motivation

Bixler and Bixler Criteria (1945)

1. **Well-Defined Knowledge Base**
    - Organized body of knowledge
    - Higher intellectual level training
2. **Continuous Knowledge Enhancement**
    - Constant expansion of knowledge
    - Improved techniques through scientific method
3. **Higher Education**
    - Education through higher institutions
    - Professional preparation
4. **Practical Application**

Kelley's Extended Criteria (1981)

1. Vital services to humanity
2. Continuous research-based knowledge
3. Intellectual activities with accountability
4. Higher education requirement
5. Professional independence
6. Service motivation
7. Ethical code guidance
8. Professional organization support

Key Professional Statements

Service and Society

> "The services provided are vital to humanity and the welfare of society"

- If 10 students are asked why they chose nursing, most would reply, "To help people"
- Essential to well-being of people and society
- Promotes health maintenance and restoration

Knowledge and Research

> "There is a special body of knowledge that is continually enlarged through research"

- Evolution from borrowed principles to own research base
- Rapid expansion in last 20 years
- Shift from task orientation to research-based practice

Intellectual Activities and Accountability

> "The services involve intellectual activities; individual responsibility (accountability) is a strong feature"

Key Features:

- Unique nursing process
- Critical and creative thinking
- Individual accountability as practice hallmark

Professional Independence

> "Practitioners are relatively independent and control their own policies and activities (Autonomy)"

Current Challenges:

- Hospital hierarchy constraints
- Physician authorization requirements
- Multiple controlling groups:
    i. Organized medicine
    ii. Health service administration
    iii. Organized nursing

Service Motivation

> "Practitioners are motivated by service (Altruism) and consider their work as an important component of their lives"

Key Points:

- Dedication to service
- Balance between altruism and economic needs
- Professional value recognition

Ethical Framework

> "There is a code of ethics to guide the decisions and conduct of practitioners"

Standards:

- Professional framework for decision-making
- Public trust maintenance
- ICN and ANA established codes

Professional Organization

> "There is an organization (association) that encourages and supports high standards of practice"

Current Status:

- Multiple professional associations
- ANA as primary advocate
- Challenge: Only 10% membership of 2.2 million nurses

1. **Service to Humanity**
    - Essential to society's well-being
    - Focuses on health maintenance and restoration
    - Promotes highest level of wellness

Current Status and Future Directions

Strengths

- Essential healthcare service
- Growing research base
- Structured education system
- Established ethical codes
- Professional organizations

Challenges

- Educational pathway diversity
- Autonomy limitations
- Professional organization membership

Professional Development in Nursing

Key Areas for Growth

1. Educational standardization
2. Professional autonomy
3. Research advancement
4. Organization unity
5. Practice control

Future Directions

- Enhanced educational requirements
- Increased professional independence
- Strengthened collective voice

References and Further Reading

- American Nurses Association (ANA) Code of Ethics
- International Council of Nurses (ICN) Standards
- Professional Nursing Organizations
- Contemporary Nursing Research
- Healthcare Policy Resources

Discussion Points for Students

1. How does nursing meet professional criteria?
2. What challenges exist in nursing professionalization?
3. How can individual nurses contribute to professional development?
4. What role does education play in professional status?
5. How can nursing enhance its professional autonomy?

Thank You

For additional resources and information:

- Contact your nursing faculty
- Visit professional nursing organization websites
- Engage with nursing research journals
- Participate in professional development activities